SOS Redouble

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An SOS redouble occurs after your side's contract has been doubled for penalty. A redouble is "SOS", named for the distress calls made by ships at sea. It has the following characteristics:

- Support for at least two of the unbid suits (4+ cards each).
- Lack of support for partner's suit, if he has bid. This typically means a singleton or void.

The redouble demands that partner bid a new suit, as in the following examples.

Examples

East
♠5432
♥--
♦JT987
♣J753

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	Pass	Dbl (1)
Pass	Pass (2)	Redbl (3)	

1. Takeout double
2. Converting the double to penalties
3. SOS redouble, asking partner to bid another suit

East
♠6
♥T8753
♦JT752
♣54

West	North	East	South
1♠	Pass	Pass	Dbl (1)
Pass	Pass (2)	Redbl (3)	

1. Takeout double
2. Converting to penalties
3. SOS, planning to correct to 2♦ if partner bids 2♣

East
♠72
♥T9732

West	North	East	South
			1♠

♦2 ♣J8654	2♦ Pass	Pass Pass (2)	Pass Redbl (3)	Dbl (1)

1. Takeout double
2. Uh-oh
3. SOS

The following example illustrates how opener can make an SOS redouble herself:

East				
♠AQ2 ♥J976 ♦AQJ ♣T83	West	North	East 1♣	South Dbl (1)
	Pass	Pass (2)	Redbl (3)	

1. Takeout double
2. Doh
3. A redouble is compelling despite imperfect shape

Other Considerations

How high to play SOS redoubles depends on partnership agreement. The SAYC bidding system advises playing SOS redoubles through the 3-level.

Of bigger concern is **when** to play SOS redoubles. One of the worst things that can happen in an auction is hearing partner pass your SOS redouble. For instance, how about these redoubles?

West	North	East	South
2♦ (1)	2♥	Dbl (2)	Pass
Pass	Redbl (3)		

1. Weak two
2. For penalty
3. SOS with 5-4-1-3 or 5-4-0-4 shape? Or for business?

West	North	East	South
1♣	1♠	2♣	Dbl
Redbl (1)			

1. SOS? Or showing extra strength or club length?

Whatever you decide, it's a good subject for partnership discussion. Some possible conditions when SOS redoubles are "off":

- You've been doubled in a known 8-card fit or longer. For example, the auction has begun 1♠ : 3♠.
- You've been doubled in a no-trump contract. Redouble may be a conventional runout (example: Touching Escapes), or it may simply be for business.

Happy hunting!